Return from the Depot!

By Elizabeth Crane

Naturally, there are people who think I need counseling. They tell me that I'm in denial. They say "I'm here for you." They say "You can call anytime just to talk." They say, "Three years is a long time, it might be time to let go." I'm not angry with them. Some of them have lost people too. But there's something they don't understand. My mother is coming back!

INTRODUCTION

The shock that is felt after the death of a parent may continue for weeks, months, or even years. "Forgetting" that your loved one is gone, you may expect her to walk in the door or to be on the other end of the line when the telephone rings. And each time it happens, you're confronted once again with the brutal reality that she is gone forever. Denial is an understandable defense against that brutal reality. It blunts the impact of the loss and allows you to process those overwhelming feelings more gradually. On one level you recognize that your mother has died; on another level you're unable to grasp all the ramifications of that harsh and unwelcome reality. In Return from the Depot! The self-defense of denial takes on a more ominous tone, one that brings the speaker to the brink of sanity itself.

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Denial, anger, bargaining, depression, acceptance. As I said, the collective belief is that I'm stuck in the denial phase when in fact, my belief is that this is just a big mistake that will eventually be straightened out. If anything, I'm in phase two (anger) because I have quite a bit of a bone to pick with whoever's in charge and frankly I'd be willing to strike all kinds of bargains if I knew who that was. But it's hard to be depressed when you know with absolute certainty that sooner or later the person who everyone else things is dead is coming back. There's nothing to be depressed about. And there's certainly nothing to accept.

I went to psychics. I thought a psychic would be the first to see my point of view, to say, "Of course it was a terrible mistake," and that they would then immediately locate the perpetrators of the mistake, that they would say something like. "You need to go speak with Fritz Miller in the accounting department. He'll give you the appropriate paperwork and straighten the whole thing out." But they don't; they, too, offer earnest sentiments and tilted heads and the best they'll do is say, "She wants you to know she's fine. She's in a better place." And when I'd ask for the

exact location of the better place they say things like "the other side," which isn't of much use, and I spent a lot of time trying to figure out the other side of WHAT?

I've been back at work since shortly after the funeral, more earnest looks and whispers, and I try to keep her house up as best I can, which is sometimes hard because I live in Chicago and the house is in New Jersey, but I go back a few times a year and I have a gardener and a housekeeper come every once in a while so the place will look nice when she gets back.

My mother's friends and family grieved. They sobbed, they went to groups, the accepted. I waited. And as it turned out, I was right. Mom came back.

Things were a little different than I expected.

She'd been waiting in a bus depot sixty miles southeast of Minot, North Dakota. She was told that there were delays. That there were weather problems. That there were engine problems. That there were traffic problems. I said, "For three years?" She said, "Tell me about it. Then she said, "Finally they admitted there was a mix-up with my ticket." "Your ticket?" I said. "Yes," she said, "I only got a one-way." I asked how she got there. She said, "There's a

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tunnel system underground that shuttles people out of graveyards when mistakes like these are made that go to this bus depot in North Dakota, and from there you're supposed to get a ticket back to wherever you came from. But in this case another mistake was made."

"I knew it!" I said. Mom, I'm just so glad to see you."

"I'm glad to see you too, sweetheart," she said. "Is there any mail."

I tried to explain that everyone on the planet besides me had thought she was dead all this time, thus the lack of mail.

"Well, Christ," she said, "that's quite an assumption to make."

"I know!" I said.

Anyway, the neighbors saw us in the yard and of course they were beside themselves, because unlike me, no one was expecting this. The Marksons next door, whose son I used to babysit, walked over crying hysterically, and seemed confused. Mom tried to explain just as Ginny the religious fanatic from up the street walked by with her dog, screaming at the sight of my mother. She crossed herself and actually fell down on the grass screaming some prayers

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or something. Later that day we figured it was Ginny who called the local news stations, because suddenly there were half a dozen trucks. My mother invited them in, the reporters, put on a big pot of coffee, and held a press conference in the living room. She explained the whole story about the bus depot and not one of them asked any kind of pressing question about how unbelievable the story was, suddenly everyone seemed to have no questions about what they wanted to institutionalize me for saying not too long before They were like, "Bus depot, underground shuttle, sure." And she had the death certificate, and she told them if there was any question at all to call the doctors, and the minister who gave her eulogy, and everyone who came to her funeral and saw her in the coffin three years ago looking pretty dead. And they did check that all out and it was all verified although there was curiously no evidence of the bus depot in question or for that matter any other returned-from-the-dead people. But no one questioned that my mother bas back. She obviously was.

Out of all the hoopla came an unexpected bonus as far as my mother was concerned. She became a celebrity. She

4N6 Fanatics

went on talk shows. She gave interviews. It seemed to extend past the allotted fifteen minutes. And then it happened. My mother got an offer to have her own TV show, a sitcom based on her life/death/return from the bus depot. That's what they called it, actually. Return from the Depot! Featuring my mom as herself, Lindsay Wagner as Ginny the religious fanatic and Alyssa Milano playing me. *I know!*

Of course the show was a big hit. At the end of the show's first season they brought in Alan Thicke for a guest spot and he fell madly in love with Mom right away. It took her all of about three months to agree to marry him. I couldn't blame her for wanting to be with someone. But I was a little jealous. All that time I'd been waiting for her to come back, I thought we'd get to spend more time together. I had a long time to think about how stupid I'd been so many time, what a waste of time it was, blaming her for everything that was wrong in my life. I thought if she came back I'd be a better daughter. I thought she'd be a better mother. I thought, dying and coming back, especially after being gone so long, it would have to change things. You would just naturally want to make things right.

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So I eventually went back to Chicago. Mom would call once every week or so to say hi. But [when] I called Mom from my cell phone, Alan answered. I asked if Mom was there and he said, "Who?" and I said, "Mom, your wife, Mrs. Thicke" and he said, "I don't know who you are or how you got this number young lady." So I called her at work, but the woman who answered sounded an awful lot like Mrs. C from Happy Days, and she was pleasant with me but she hung up as soon as she said, "I think you have the wrong number." I called the Marksons, who said, "Sweetie, we thought you let this go already." I called Ginny the religious fanatic who said something about "messing with god's will" and said a Hail Mary and hung up on me. I looked at the TV Guide for the listing for Return from the Depot! And there was a big ad for the show with a picture of Mrs. Cunningham with the rest of the cast, no mention of my mother, and no indication that she was just replaced or something. It seems clear she was never there.

Now, I know what you're thinking . You're thinking this is the part where I realize that my mother is not coming back, the part where I snap out of my denial and realize that there will be no big reunion, that she will not send me

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vitamins or make me chicken soup again when I'm sick. Where I realize that we will never decorate another Christmas tree . . . where I understand that I will never get to show her the home movies from my childhood that Dad put on video that I forgot to bring to Jersey the last time before she died. . . Where I understand that I will never get to tell her that even though she was compete crazy that I would never in a million years want any other mom. . . the part where I realize that I will never get to ask her all the questions I wanted to ask her . . . what was it like for her when Granma died? The part where I understand why my mother wasn't there to help me get through my mother's death, because it still make perfect sense to me that anyone would need their mom at a time like that. But it isn't. I flew to North Dakota. I rented a car and drove to every bus station south of Minot and showed people pictures of my mom. I was pretty close to giving it up just out of exhaustion. Finally, I found a guy who said there had been someone there who looked like her, and I ended up explaining the entire situation. Finally he said, "That's a sad story. I'm really sorry that happened to you." And it was hard to tell whether he really believed me or not, but he

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could obviously tell that I needed someone to believe me,

and I'm grateful to him for that.

Mom hasn't come back again . . . . Yet.

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AWARD HISTORY

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